

1 GAME OVERVIEW

Objective Create ascending paths through your arboretum, while keeping the right cards in hand to earn permission to score them. Highest final score wins.

Players 2-4 Play time About 30 minutes Complexity Light-medium

Win by balancing two needs: plant useful paths on the table and retain valuable species cards in your 7-card hand.

2 SETUP CHRONOLOGY

- A. Choose species for the deck. Use 6 species for 2 players (48 cards), 8 for 3 players (64), or all 10 for 4 players (80). Remove unused species.
 - B. Choose the start player. The person who most recently watered a plant starts. The player to the start player's right is the dealer.
 - C. Deal hands. Shuffle the selected species and deal 7 cards face down to every player.
 - D. Form the draw pile. Place all remaining cards face down within everyone's reach.
 - E. Start discard piles. In a 2-player game, deal 1 face-up card to the non-starting player. In a 3-player game, deal 1 face-up card to the second player and 2 face-up cards to the third player. In a 4-player game, deal 1, 2, and 3 face-up cards respectively to the players after the start player. Each set forms that player's discard pile.
- Reminder: Keep each discard pile separate and fully visible. Each player needs open table space to expand an orthogonal card grid.

3 STRUCTURE OF A TURN

1 DRAW 2

Draw one card at a time. Each may come from the face-down draw pile or the top of any player's face-up discard pile, including your own.

2 PLAY 1

Place 1 card face up. Your first card may go anywhere; later cards must be horizontally or vertically adjacent to a card in your arboretum.

3 DISCARD 1

Place 1 card face up on your personal discard pile. After discarding, your hand must contain exactly 7 cards.

4 PASS TURN

Play continues clockwise. Cards already planted may not be moved, covered, or rearranged.

4 TABLE SETUP



Table setup example. Each player develops an individual arboretum and discard pile around one shared draw pile. The supplied photo is cropped to emphasize card layout and scorepad; component artwork may vary by edition.

1 KEY MECHANICS / RULES REFRESHER

Drawing

- Draw 2 cards, one at a time. Each draw may use a different source or the same source.
- The only available discard from a pile is its top face-up card. If you draw from the deck first, look at that card before choosing the second source.

Planting

- After your first planted card, every new card must touch at least one existing card along a full horizontal or vertical edge. Diagonal contact does not count.
- Once planted, a card cannot be moved, covered, removed, or rearranged.

Paths

- A valid scoring path is an orthogonally connected sequence whose values strictly increase from card to card.
- Only the first and last cards must match the species being scored. Interior cards may be any species.
- A tree card may be used in more than one scoring path. For each species, score only your single best eligible path.

Permission to score

- For each species, reveal hand cards of that species. Highest total gains the right to score; tied players all gain the right.
- Special 1 vs. 8 rule: if one player holds the 8 and an opponent holds the 1 of that species, that 8 counts as 0 for permission only. The 1 still counts as 1.
- If nobody holds that species, all players may score it. Winning permission does not guarantee points if no valid path exists.

Frequently forgotten

- You finish every turn with exactly 7 cards. Your hand is both hidden information and your end-game scoring leverage.

2 SCORING SUMMARY

1. Determine scoring rights

Resolve species one at a time using the hand-total rules at left.

2. Identify a path

Choose an orthogonally adjacent, strictly ascending path that starts and ends with the species being scored.

3. Score the path

- +1 point for each card in the path.
- +1 per card again if the path has at least 4 cards and every card is the scoring species.
- +1 point if the path begins with a 1.
- +2 points if the path ends with an 8.

Quick example

A five-card path worth 5 points that begins with 1 and ends with 8 scores 8. If all five cards are the scoring species, it scores 13.

Important

- The smallest scoring path has 2 cards of the same species: matching endpoints with increasing values.
- A path can bend, but it cannot move diagonally and every next value must be higher.
- Holding a large species total may block opponents even when you cannot score that species yourself.

3 STRATEGIC TIPS

GOOD HABITS

- Plan flexible junctions so one interior card can support several possible paths.
- Track exposed discard cards before deciding where to draw.
- Keep enough hand value to protect the species you intend to score.

COMMON MISTAKES

- Building a beautiful path but surrendering scoring rights for its species.
- Discarding a 1 that can neutralize an opponent's held 8.
- Creating dead ends with values that cannot continue upward.

COMPETITIVE TIPS

- Use hand cards defensively to deny permission, not only to score your own paths.
- A mixed-species path is efficient, but a 4+ card monochrome path earns the powerful double-card bonus.
- Late in the deck, prioritize hand control because the draw pile can end abruptly.

4 END OF GAME

- Trigger: the draw pile is empty.
- The player who drew the final card completes the turn normally. Then resolve scoring rights and paths for every species.
- Winner: highest total score.
- Tie: most species represented in the tied player's arboretum wins. If still tied, the rulebook gives a playful tree-growing tiebreaker.